



Insignia for the Bengal and Assam Railway (BAR)

Transporting refugees

The subcontinent became a sanctuary for people fleeing Burma ahead of the oncoming Japanese assault. Refugees crossed the border and poured into Assam, from where the railways transported them across India. Despite the fact that the Middle Eastern war effort had severely depleted its stock, the BAR transported more than 200,000 refugees by rail.

The staff worked continuously to prevent congestion and special trains were run for the mission. As most of the refugees were unable to pay for their train fare, the Government assumed the cost of their journey. Civilian groups gathered at the stations along the evacuation train routes, providing aid in the form of biscuits, hot tea, cheese, and jam as food was in short supply on the trains.

Military asset

Due to military activity along the eastern front, the metre-gauge railway in Assam was considered a part of the war zone and was thus controlled by the armed forces. The army's needs were prioritized over